“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 21

The Sweetness of Śrī Kṛṣṇa and His Boundless Glories

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 Having bowed to Śrī Caitanya, the only refuge of the shelterless, who grants the highest gift to the deprived, I write of a drop of His sweetness and majesty.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 The abode of all the Lord’s forms is the realm of Paravyoma. There each form has its own Vaikuṇṭha, and they are beyond counting.

4 The extent of each Vaikuṇṭha is described in hundreds, thousands, tens of thousands, hundreds of thousands and tens of millions of *yojanas*.

5 All the Vaikuṇṭhas are all-pervading, made of bliss and spirit, and all are full of associates and of the six opulences.

6 Who can measure the expanse of that Paravyoma, in each part of which lie endless Vaikuṇṭhas?

7 It is a lotus whose rows of petals are the endless Vaikuṇṭhas of Paravyoma; above them all, Kṛṣṇaloka is its whorl (*karṇikā*).

8 Such are His six opulences, His abodes and His *avatāras*. Even Brahmā and Śiva cannot find their end — what then of the insignificant *jīva*?

9 “O Bhūman, O Bhagavān, O Supreme Soul, O Lord of yoga! Who in the three worlds can know where, how, how many and when are Your pastimes, as You play, expanding Your Yogamāyā?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.21)

10 So endless are Kṛṣṇa’s divine virtues that even Brahmā, Śiva, Sanaka and the other sages cannot find their end.

11 “In the course of time the most skilled may have counted the particles of the earth, the snowflakes in the sky and the rays of the luminaries. But who among them could count the qualities of You, the Lord of all qualities, who have descended for the good of the world?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.7)

12 Leave aside Brahmā and the others: Ananta sings ceaselessly with His thousand mouths, yet He finds no end to Kṛṣṇa’s qualities.

13 “Neither I nor these sages, your elder brothers, know the end of the Supreme Person, the Master of the power of māyā — how then could others? Even Śeṣa, the original Lord, who sings His qualities with a thousand mouths, has not reached their far shore to this day.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.7.41)

14 Leave Him aside: Śrī Kṛṣṇa Himself, the crest-jewel of the omniscient, cannot find the end of His own qualities, and so He is filled with longing.

15 “Because You are endless, even the lords of heaven have not reached Your end — nor do You Yourself, for within You multitudes of universes, each in its coverings, revolve together with time like specks of dust in the sky. Therefore the *śrutis*, rejecting all that is not You, bear their fruit in You and find their conclusion in You.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.87.41)

16 Leave that aside as well. When Kṛṣṇa descended in Vraja, the mind could find no end in pondering His deeds.

17 In a single moment He made both the material and the transcendental creation — countless Vaikuṇṭhas and universes, each with its own lord.

18 Nowhere else does one hear of such a wonder. Simply by hearing of it, the heart is overwhelmed.

19 “With Kṛṣṇa’s countless calves” — so says Śukadeva. How many cowherd boys were with Kṛṣṇa I do not know: their number is not known.

20 The calves that each cowherd boy herded were counted in *koṭis*, *arbudas*, *śaṅkhas* and *padmas* — tens of millions, hundreds of millions, trillions, tens of trillions.

21 Canes, flutes, leaves, horns, garments and ornaments — however many the cowherd boys had, there is no end to writing of them.

22 All of them became four-armed lords of Vaikuṇṭha, and the Brahmās of separate universes offered them praise.

23 All of them were manifested from Kṛṣṇa’s one body, and in a moment they all entered that same body again.

24 Seeing this, Brahmā was bewildered and astonished. After offering praise, he came to this conclusion:

25 “If someone says, ‘I know all of Kṛṣṇa’s glory,’ let him know it. As for me, with body and mind I accept this:

26 of this endless nectar ocean of Your glory, not a single drop lies within reach of my speech and mind.

27 ‘Let those who know go on knowing. What use is much talk? O Lord, Your glory is beyond the reach of my mind, body and speech.’” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.38)

28 Leave aside Kṛṣṇa’s own glory — who can know it? Behold instead the wondrous majesty of the land of Vṛndāvana.

29 Vṛndāvana measures sixteen *krośas*, as the scriptures reveal; yet in a single part of it multitudes of Vaikuṇṭhas and universes float.

30 Kṛṣṇa’s opulence is boundless, beyond counting. I have only pointed toward it, as one shows the moon by pointing to a branch (*śākhā-candra-nyāya*).

31 As He described this opulence, an ocean of opulence surged up within Him. His mind and senses sank in it, and the Lord was overwhelmed.

32 He Himself recited this verse of the *Bhāgavatam*, and to relish its meaning He joyfully explained it.

33 “He Himself has none equal to Him and none above Him; He is the Lord of the three. Through Svārājya-lakṣmī, the wealth of His own realm, all His desires are fulfilled. The age-old guardians of the worlds bring Him tribute and praise His footstool with the tips of their crowns.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.2.21)

34 Kṛṣṇa is the Supreme Lord, Bhagavān Himself. There is no one else greater than Him or equal to Him.

35 “Kṛṣṇa, Govinda, is the Supreme Lord; His form is eternal being, knowledge and bliss. He has no beginning, yet He is the beginning of all, the cause of all causes.” (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.1)

36 Brahmā, Viṣṇu and Hara (Śiva) are the lords of creation, maintenance and destruction. All three carry out Kṛṣṇa's orders, and Kṛṣṇa is their Supreme Lord.

37 "Appointed by Him, I create; under His control Hara (Śiva) destroys; and He, the bearer of the three potencies, maintains the universe in the form of the Puruṣa." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.6.32)

38 That is the general meaning. Now hear another meaning of *tryadhīśvara*, "the Lord of the three": the three Puruṣa-avatāras, the causes of the world.

39 Mahā-Viṣṇu, Padmanābha and the Lord of the Milk Ocean — these three are the indwelling Lords of the gross, of the subtle and of all.

40 These three are the shelter of all and the lords of the world. Yet They are only His parts (*kalā* and *aṁśa*), and Kṛṣṇa is Their Supreme Lord.

41 "The lords of the universes, born from His pores, abide for the span of one of His breaths. That Mahā-Viṣṇu is a particular kalā of Govinda, the original Person, whom I worship." (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.48)

42 That meaning is external; now hear the hidden one. Kṛṣṇa has three abodes, renowned in the scriptures.

43 His inner abode (*antaḥpura*) is Goloka, Śrī Vṛndāvana, where His mother, father and friends dwell eternally.

44 It is the storehouse of sweet majesty, sweetness, mercy and every other treasure. There Yogamāyā is the maidservant, and there are the *rāsa* and the other pastimes, the essence of all *līlā*.

45 “When the son of the king of Vraja triumphs — He who is tender with abundant mercy and graced with a special sweet majesty — not even a particle of anxiety arises in us.”

46 Below it lies Paravyoma, called Viṣṇuloka, the abode of Nārāyaṇa and His other endless forms.

47 This is Kṛṣṇa’s middle abode (*madhyama-āvāsa*), the treasury of the six opulences, where He sports in endless forms.

48 There the endless Vaikuṇṭhas are the rooms of the treasury, filled with associates and with the six opulences.

49 “Below His own abode, called Goloka, lie the abodes of Devī, Maheśa and Hari, and in each of them He established its own powers. I worship that Govinda, the original Person.” (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.43)

50 “Between *pradhāna* and the supreme spiritual sky flows the auspicious river Virajā, streaming with waters born of the sweat of the Lord, whose limbs are the Vedas.” (Padma Purāṇa, Uttara-khaṇḍa, 255.57)

51 “Beyond it lies Paravyoma, the eternal realm of three quarters (*tripād-bhūta*) — immortal, everlasting, endless, the supreme abode.” (Padma Purāṇa)

52 Below it, beyond the Virajā, lies the outer abode (*bāhyāvāsa*), whose countless rooms are the endless universes.

53 Its name is Devī-dhāma, and its residents are the *jīvas*. Jagal-lakṣmī maintains it, and there Māyā remains as a maidservant.

54 Kṛṣṇa is the Supreme Lord of these three abodes. Goloka and Paravyoma lie beyond material nature.

55 The abode of the opulence of His spiritual potency is called *tripād-aiśvarya*, the opulence of three quarters; the opulence of māyā is called *ekapāda*, one quarter.

56 “That realm is called *tripād-bhūta*, ‘consisting of three quarters’, because it is the abode of the opulence of three quarters; all the opulence of māyā is declared to be one quarter.” (Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta, 1.5.286)

57 Kṛṣṇa’s opulence of three quarters lies beyond words. Hear now a description of the opulence of one quarter.

58 All the Brahmās and Rudras of the endless universes are meant by the words “the age-old guardians of the worlds” (*cira-loka-pāla*).

59 One day Brahmā came to Dvārakā to see Kṛṣṇa, and the doorkeeper informed Kṛṣṇa.

60 Kṛṣṇa said, “Which Brahmā? What is his name?” The doorkeeper went back and asked Brahmā once more.

61 Astonished, Brahmā told the doorkeeper, “Go and tell Him that the four-headed Brahmā, the father of Sanaka, has come.”

62 The doorkeeper informed Kṛṣṇa and brought Brahmā in, and Brahmā fell prostrate at Kṛṣṇa’s feet.

63 Kṛṣṇa honoured him with due respect and asked, “For what purpose have you come here?”

64 Brahmā said, “I will tell You that later. First, please cut away a doubt that has arisen in my mind.

65 With what intention did You ask, ‘Which Brahmā?’ Besides me, what other Brahmā is there in the universe?”

66 Hearing this, Kṛṣṇa smiled and became absorbed in meditation, and at that very moment countless Brahmās arrived.

67 Some had ten faces, some twenty, a hundred, a thousand, ten thousand, a hundred thousand; some had tens and hundreds of millions of faces — they could not be counted.

68 Rudras came with hundreds of thousands and millions of faces, and Indras came with hundreds of thousands and millions of eyes.

69 Seeing this, four-headed Brahmā was bewildered, like a rabbit standing amid a herd of elephants.

70 All the Brahmās came before Kṛṣṇa’s footstool, and as they offered obeisance their crowns touched it.

71 No one can describe Kṛṣṇa’s inconceivable power: as many Brahmās as there were, so many forms were in His one body.

72 As the tips of the crowns struck the footstool, a sound arose; it seemed to me that the crowns were offering praise to the footstool.

73 With joined palms the Brahmās, the Rudras and the others offered praise: “O Lord, You have shown great mercy in revealing Your feet.

74 It is my good fortune that You have called me, accepting me as Your servant. Whatever Your order may be, I will carry it out, placing it on my head.”

75 Kṛṣṇa said, “I wished to see you all, and so I have called you all together in one place.

76 Are you all happy? Have you no fear of the demons?” They replied, “By Your grace we are victorious everywhere.

77 Whatever burden had lately come upon the earth, You have descended and destroyed it.”

78 This is the proof of the opulence (*vibhūti*) of Dvārakā and Kṛṣṇa’s other abodes: each of them understood, “Kṛṣṇa is in my own universe.”

79 Each experienced the splendour of Dvārakā together with Kṛṣṇa; yet, though all met in one place, none of them saw any other.

80 Then Kṛṣṇa gave all the Brahmās leave to go, and they all bowed down flat and returned to their own homes.

81 Seeing this, the four-headed Brahmā was amazed. He came to Kṛṣṇa’s feet and offered obeisance.

82 Brahmā said, “What I concluded before, today I have seen demonstrated before my eyes.

83 “Let those who know You know. What use are many words? O Lord, Your glory lies beyond the reach of my mind, my body and my speech.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.38)

84 Kṛṣṇa said, “This universe measures fifty crore *yojanas*. It is very small, and so you have only four faces.

85 Some universes measure a hundred crore *yojanas*, some a hundred thousand crore, some a million crore, some crore upon crore.

86 A Brahmā's body and faces correspond to the size of his universe. In this way I maintain the countless universes.

87 The *eka-pāda vibhūti*, the one quarter of My opulence, has no measure. Who, then, can measure the *tri-pāda vibhūti*, the other three quarters?"

88 "On the far shore of the Virajā lies Paravyoma, the eternal three quarters of His opulence: immortal, everlasting and constant, infinite, the supreme abode." (Padma Purāṇa)

89 Then Kṛṣṇa gave Brahmā leave to go. The nature of Kṛṣṇa's opulence cannot be known.

90 The word *tryadhīśvara* ("Lord of the three") has yet another, hidden meaning: by the word *tri* ("three") Kṛṣṇa's three abodes are meant.

91 Gokula, which is called Goloka, Mathurā and Dvārāvatī (Dvārakā): in these three abodes Kṛṣṇa naturally and eternally resides.

92 These three abodes are internal and filled with full majesty, and their supreme master is Kṛṣṇa, Bhagavān Himself.

93–94 All the guardians of the quarters in the universes I spoke of before, and the age-old guardians of the worlds in the infinite Vaikuṇṭhas and the coverings of the universes, bow down before Kṛṣṇa's footstool, and as they prostrate themselves the jewels of their crowns touch it.

95 The jewels knock together on the footstool and a jingling arises: it is as if, I think, the crowns were singing the footstool's praises.

96 Kṛṣṇa is eternally present with His own spiritual potency (*cit-śakti*), and the wealth of that potency is called the "six opulences"

(*ṣaḍaiśvarya*).

97 That Svārājya-lakṣmī, the wealth of His own realm, keeps Him eternally fulfilled in every desire, and therefore the Vedas call Him “Bhagavān Himself.”

98 Kṛṣṇa’s majesty is a boundless ocean of nectar. Unable to plunge into it, I have touched but a single drop.”

99 As the Lord spoke of majesty, Kṛṣṇa was revealed within His heart. His mind sank into sweetness, and He recited a verse.

100 “To display the power of His own Yogamāyā, He assumed a form suited to His pastimes among mortals — a form that astonished even Himself, the supreme abode of all good fortune, whose limbs are the ornament of ornaments.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.2.12)

101 Of all Kṛṣṇa’s pastimes the highest is His human-like pastime (*nara-līlā*), and a human-like form is His own true form. Dressed as a cowherd boy, flute in hand, ever freshly youthful, the finest of dancers — this form perfectly suits His human-like pastimes.

102 Hear, Sanātana, of Kṛṣṇa’s sweet form, a single particle of which floods the three worlds and draws all living beings to itself.

103 Yogamāyā is the spiritual potency (*cit-śakti*), a transformation of pure *sattva* (*viśuddha-sattva*). To show her power to the world, He brought this jewel of a form, the hidden treasure of the devotees, into the manifest world from His eternal pastimes.

104 Seeing His own form, Kṛṣṇa is amazed, and a desire to taste it rises in His mind. His own good fortune (*sva-saubhāgya*), the host of qualities beginning with beauty, has this form as its eternal abode.

105 His body is the ornament of ornaments, and in it is the graceful threefold bending (*tribhaṅga*). Above it dances the bow of His brows; the arrows of His sidelong glances, firmly aimed, pierce the hearts of Rādhā and the gopīs.

106 Above the universes lies Paravyoma; this form forcibly steals the minds of all the divine forms (*svarūpas*) there. It attracts even the Lakṣmīs, whom the word of the Vedas calls the crest-jewels of chaste wives.

107 Mounted on the chariot of the gopīs' heartfelt desire, He churns the mind of Cupid himself, and so He bears the name Madana-mohana, the enchanter of Cupid. Conquering the pride of the five-arrowed god, He, Himself a new Cupid (*nava-kandarpa*), performs the *rāsa* dance with the gopīs.

108 With friends equal to Himself, in the joy of grazing the cows, He sports freely in Vṛndāvana. Hearing the sound of His flute, all beings, unmoving and moving, thrill and tremble, and tears flow from them in streams.

109 His pearl necklace is a line of herons, His peacock feather the rainbow, His yellow garment a flash of lightning. Kṛṣṇa is a fresh rain cloud pouring showers of the nectar of His pastimes upon the crops of the world.

110 Sweetness, the essence of Godhood (*bhagavattā*), He made known in Vraja. Śuka, the son of Vyāsa, has described it in place after place in the *Bhāgavata* to make it known, and hearing it the devotees dance.

111 Speaking of the *rasa* of Kṛṣṇa, the Lord, in the rapture of love, lovingly took Sanātana's hand and recited the verse in which the women of Mathurā, absorbed in ecstasy, described the gopīs' fortune and Kṛṣṇa's qualities.

112 “What austerities did the gopīs perform, that with their eyes they drink His form — the essence of loveliness, unequalled and unsurpassed, perfect in itself, new at every moment, hard to attain, the sole abode of fame, beauty and majesty?” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.44.14)

113 His youth is a nectar ocean; its waves are the essence of loveliness, its whirlpools the surging of emotions. The sound of His flute is a whirlwind, and women’s pride is but grass and leaves: the whirlwind sinks it, and it never rises again.

114 O friend, what austerity did the gopīs perform? Drinking and drinking the exquisite sweetness of Kṛṣṇa’s form until their eyes are full, they make their birth, body and mind worthy of praise.

115 Among all the divine forms in Paravyoma there is nothing higher than this sweetness, nor anything equal to it. Even Nārāyaṇa, the source of all the *avatāras* and the ruler of Paravyoma, does not possess this sweetness.

116 The witness to this is Ramā (Lakṣmī), Nārāyaṇa’s most beloved, whom all chaste wives worship. Longing for that sweetness, she gave up every enjoyment she might desire, took a vow and performed austerities.

117 That is the very essence of sweetness, owing its perfection to nothing else; He is the mine of sweetness and of all other qualities. In all His other manifestations shine the qualities He grants them, as much in each as its work requires — this I know.

118 The gopīs’ love is a mirror, new at every moment, and before it stands Kṛṣṇa’s sweetness. The two vie with each other and keep growing, never turning back, and the abundance of both is ever new.

119 Through *karma*, austerity, yoga, knowledge, devotion according to rules (*vidhi-bhakti*), *japa* or meditation this sweetness is hard to attain.

Only one who worships Kṛṣṇa with deep attachment (*anurāga*) on the path of spontaneous love (*rāga-mārga*) attains Kṛṣṇa's sweetness easily.

120 That form, whose home is Vraja, is full of majesty and sweetness, a jewel-mine of divine qualities. The majestic existence of others, their Godhood (*bhagavattā*), is given by Kṛṣṇa: Kṛṣṇa is the whole of whom all are parts (*sarva-aṁśī*), the shelter of all.

121 Beauty, modesty, mercy, fame, steadfastness and skilful intelligence — all these are established in Kṛṣṇa. Good-natured, gentle and generous — there is no one so but Kṛṣṇa. Kṛṣṇa does good to the world.

122 All who saw Kṛṣṇa reproached the blinking of their eyes, and in Vraja the gopīs reproached the Creator. Reciting those verses and explaining their meaning, Mahāprabhu joyfully tasted their sweetness.

123 "Women and men drank with their eyes His face — lovely with ears graced by *makara* earrings and with shining cheeks, smiling playfully, an eternal festival — and were never sated. Delighted, they were angry with the maker of the blinking eyelids." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 9.24.65)

124 "When by day You wander in the forest, a moment without You becomes an age for us. And as we gaze upon Your beautiful face framed in curling locks, we see what a fool was the maker of our eyelids." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.31.15)

125 The form of the Kāma-gāyatrī mantra is Kṛṣṇa's own form. It has twenty-four and a half syllables; those syllables are moons, and, making Kṛṣṇa rise, they have filled the three worlds with love's desire (*kāma*).

126 O friend, Kṛṣṇa's face is the emperor of moons. Seated on the throne of Kṛṣṇa's body, it rules its kingdom, holding court with an assembly of moons.

127 His two glossy cheeks, surpassing fine jewelled mirrors, I know to be two full moons. On His forehead is a half-moon, and on it a dot of sandal paste: that too I count as a full moon.

128 The nails of His fingers, a company of moons, dance upon the flute, and their song is the flute's melody. Below, the moons of His toenails dance, and the jingling of His anklets is their song.

129 The *makara* earrings dance, and the eyes, playful lotuses: the pleasure-loving king makes them dance without cease. His brows are a bow, His eyes arrows, His two ears the bowstring; with them He pierces the target, the hearts of women.

130 Grand is this moon's dance: spreading out a market of moons, it gives away its own nectar without price. Some it satisfies with the moonlit nectar of His smile, some with the nectar of His lips — it satisfies everyone.

131 Its ministers are His two eyes, broad, long and reddish, which make even Madana (Cupid) reel in his intoxication. Govinda's face, full of joy, is the pleasure-house of loveliness and an elixir for the eyes of all.

132 One who obtains the sight of that face as the fruit of heaps of piety — what can his two eyes drink of it? His thirst and greed grow twofold; unable to drink, his mind is agitated, and in sorrow he reproaches the Creator:

133 "He did not give hundreds of thousands, millions of eyes; he gave only two, and on them he put blinking lids. The Creator is a dull ascetic; his mind is void of taste (*rasa*), and he does not know how to create properly.

134 For one who is to see Kṛṣṇa's face he makes only two eyes — such injustice from the Creator! If he would take my advice and make millions of eyes for such a one, then I would know his creation to be proper."

135 The sweetness of Kṛṣṇa's body is an ocean, His very sweet face the moon, and His exceedingly sweet smile its fine rays. The Lord's mind clung to these three; greedily He tasted them and, waving His hand, recited a verse.

136 "Sweet, sweet is the form of this Lord; sweet, sweet is His face, sweet indeed; and this gentle smile, fragrant with honey — ah, it is sweet, sweet, sweet, sweet!" (Kṛṣṇa-karṇāmṛta, 92)

137 O Sanātana, Kṛṣṇa's sweetness is an ocean of nectar. My mind, delirious as in a fever (*sannipāta*), resolves to drink it all — but the physician, alas, My ill fate, will not give Me a single drop!

138 Kṛṣṇa's body is a flood of loveliness, sweeter than sweetness itself. On it is His moonlike face, sweeter than sweet and sweeter still; and His smile is the full flood of that moon's light.

139 Sweeter than sweet, sweeter still, and sweeter even than that, the smile pervades all the three worlds with a single particle of itself, and its flood fills the ten directions.

140 The fine camphor of the rays of His smile enters the sweetness of His lips, and that honey maddens the three worlds. It enters the sky within the holes of the flute and passes into sound, the sky's own quality, transformed into the form of melody.

141 That sound runs in all directions; piercing the shell of the universe, it reaches Vaikuṇṭha and forces its way into the ears of the world. Maddening all, it seizes them and brings them by force — above all the young women.

142 That sound is most insolent: it breaks the vow of chaste wives and pulls them from their husbands' laps. It attracts even the Lakṣmīs of Vaikuṇṭha — what then of the gopīs?

143 It loosens the knots of their skirts before their husbands and makes them give up their household duties; seizing them by force, it brings them to Kṛṣṇa. Social duty, modesty, fear — all awareness is lost. So it makes all the women dance.

144 It makes its home within the ears and ever sounds there by itself, letting no other sound enter. The ears hear no other talk; meaning to say one thing, one says another. Such is the way of Kṛṣṇa's flute.

145 Then, returning to outer consciousness, the Lord said again, "Meaning to say one thing, I have said another. Kṛṣṇa's mercy is upon you: bewildering My mind, He has made you hear the sweetness of His own majesty through My mouth.

146 I am a madman: meaning to say one thing, I say another. I am carried away in the stream of Kṛṣṇa's sweetness."

147 Then Mahāprabhu remained silent for a moment; collecting His mind, He spoke to Sanātana again.

148 Whoever hears this — Kṛṣṇa's sweetness from Mahāprabhu's own mouth — floats in the happiness of love.

149 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.